power. The symbols of legitimacy, for the young Mughal Empire, came in various hues and colours.

Oral tradition has it that unable to stop the departure of his beloved musician, Raja Ramachandra carried his palanquin on his shoulders himself, incognito, one last act of devotion. Tansen, who would later have a remarkably lifelike portrait made of himself at the imperial court, was a tall, angular man with a dark complexion, a hook nose, and melancholic eyes. With Tansen there would come to the Mughal court the ancient, haunting raags of Dhrupad. Far from his Baghela patron, the musician now sang for the young Akbar in a new Hindustan, in the warm and perfumed evenings of Agra.

In early 1564, Akbar attempted a further expansion of his power base that could have ended rather more calamitously for him. Wanting to marry into the shaikhzada families, the old Indian Muslim nobility of Delhi and Agra, Akbar travelled to Delhi without the harem and sent eunuchs and intermediaries to these families to find out about their marriageable daughters. According to Badauni, it was at this time that Akbar chanced to see a beautiful married woman from one of these established families. The husband, bowing to the inevitable, divorced his wife and went away to Mecca and the woman was integrated into Akbar's harem. This sudden and muscular attempt to impose Chingizid yassa law understandably alienated the Delhi Muslim nobility and 'a great terror fell upon the city', according to Badauni. Following this somewhat misguided attempt to bring the shaikhzadas into the empire's fold, Akbar was passing in front of the Khair-ul-Manazil mosque after having visited Nizamuddin Auliya's dargah when an arrow whispered through the air and struck Akbar on the shoulder. The would-be assassin was a young man named Falud, a freed slave of the disaffected Ajmer governor, Mirza Sharafuddin Hussain. Though his noblemen wanted the young Falud arrested and questioned, Akbar ordered him executed immediately. The timing of the assassination attempt, and Akbar's refusal to hear Falud's accusations, hint at the possibility that the attempt was linked to Akbar's indiscretions with the women of Delhi's Muslim nobility. All further attempts to secure alliances in this manner were stopped and, unable to ride his horse due to his injury, Akbar travelled back to Agra by litter. 'Alas that in the first flush of youth our inestimable lives are unworthily spent,' Akbar said ruefully, much later. 'Let us hope that in future they may virtuously terminate.'